

Washington - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-20 caliber with a settled quarterback and a strong two-way statistical base, but more personnel volatility than the ranking alone suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 17 (501 points) · SP+ No. 18
Returning production	65% (No. 14) overall · Off. 69% (No. 13) · Def. 61% (No. 27)
Primer power rating	+16.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Slight regression from a strong 2025 baseline, with similar top-20 underlying quality but more replacement risk at RB/WR, OL, edge and corner.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Washington should remain a quarterback-centered, efficiency-first offense under Jedd Fisch with QB Demond Williams Jr. and TE Decker DeGraaf as the most stable pieces while the backfield, receiving hierarchy and parts of the line are rebuilt.

Bottom line: Washington still deserves a ranked, top-20-quality preseason evaluation, but the Huskies need their settled QB and returning defensive spine to carry a roster replacing premium NFL talent before a punishing November finish.

Beats expectations if: QB Demond Williams Jr. sustains the 2025 efficiency profile, one of RB Quaid Carr/RB Jayden Limar/RB Trey Cooley becomes a dependable lead back, the OL gets healthy, and transfer additions stabilize corner and the defensive front.

Disappoints if: The post-WR Denzel Boston/RB Jonah Coleman skill group loses too much explosiveness, OL injuries keep the protection combinations unsettled, and the rebuilt corner/edge groups cannot reproduce 2025 defensive efficiency.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Demond Williams Jr. is the established QB1; Washington does not have a quarterback competition to manufacture.
- 2 Returning production:** The preseason consensus is genuinely strong: AP No. 17, SP+ No. 18, and 65% returning production (No. 14).
- 3 NFL departures:** Washington lost seven 2025 contributors to the NFL draft, including WR Denzel Boston, RB Jonah Coleman, CB Tacario Davis and CB Ephesians Prysock.
- 4 Coaching:** Jedd Fisch is the 2026 offensive play-caller, and Washington currently lists no OC.
- 5 Key takeaway:** The final four games are Penn State, at Michigan State, Indiana and at Oregon, turning late-season depth and health into a major outcome driver.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (5-4 Big Ten)	● Good
Scoring	34.1 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	409.9 YPG	● Good / above average
Rush offense	165.5 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	8.59 YPA · 26 TD / 8 INT	● Elite
Third downs	50.6%	● Elite
Scoring defense	18.7 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	311.4 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	100.1 YPG · 3.3 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	211.3 YPG · 6.13 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Very good

Washington paired No. 10 pass efficiency/third downs with No. 17 scoring; the defense was top-30 in scoring, total, rush and pass-efficiency defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+5.40 · No. 20	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.158 · No. 15	● Elite
Off. success rate	50.9% · No. 6	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	14.3% · No. 23	● Very good
Havoc allowed	12.9% · No. 29	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.60 · No. 24	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.087 · No. 32	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	38.0% · No. 27	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	8.9% · No. 13	● Elite
Havoc created	14.2% · No. 98	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: Both units were legitimately strong: offense was elite in EPA/success rate and defense suppressed rushing/explosives. Havoc creation was the clear weakness, making 2026 front turnover especially important.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Jedd Fisch - Returning HC; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Jedd Fisch's return preserves offensive play-calling continuity and clear top-level authority.
OC administrative status	No current OC listed - HC Jedd Fisch is the offensive play-caller	● ↔ No standalone OC is listed; Fisch retaining the calls keeps offensive command clear despite the title vacancy.
DC	Ryan Walters - Returning defensive coordinator / scheme architect	● ↔ Continuity supports a stable preseason projection

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Jayden Limar	Oregon	● ↔ Adds a credible lead-back candidate, but the Carr/RB Jayden Limar/Cooley hierarchy remains unresolved.
◆ WR Christian Moss	Kennesaw State	● ↔ Competes for a starting role and helps replace WR Denzel Boston, but his spring hamstring issue and unsettled pecking order add projection risk.
◆ OL Kolt Dieterich	Sam Houston	● ↔ Provides immediate interior-line value and first-team center reps while C Landen Hatchett works back from injury.

Out	To	Loss
RB Jonah Coleman	NFL (Denver), Round 4, No. 108	● ↓ Major proven backfield production leaves, increasing dependence on an unresolved new hierarchy.
WR Denzel Boston	NFL (Cleveland), Round 2, No. 39	● ↓ The offense loses its headline receiving threat and must redistribute high-value targets.
OT Carver Willis	NFL (San Francisco), Round 4, No. 127	● ↓ A drafted tackle departure compounds current OL health and alignment uncertainty.
OT Maximus McCree	Washington State	● ↓ Three 2025 starts and early-season left-tackle work leave the depth chart during an already unsettled line transition.

Offensive net: Step back from 2025 but still a good offense because QB and TE continuity are unusually strong.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ CB Emmanuel Karnley	Virginia	● ↔ Competes for first-unit corner work in a secondary replacing two drafted corners.
◆ EDGE Logan George	Ohio State	● ↔ Adds a major edge-rotation candidate to a front replacing EDGE Zach Durfee and other contributors.

Out	To	Loss
CB Tacario Davis	NFL (Cincinnati), Round 3, No. 72	● ↓ A drafted corner departure removes a proven piece from a secondary now leaning on transfers and returning safeties.
CB Ephesians Prysock	NFL (San Francisco), Round 5, No. 139	● ↓ A second drafted corner departure makes outside coverage the clearest defensive retooling point.
EDGE Zach Durfee	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 7, No. 233	● ↓ Removes a major edge contributor from a 2025 defense that already ranked only No. 98 in havoc created.
DT Anterio Thompson	NFL (Atlanta), Round 6, No. 208	● ↓ Interior NFL departure raises the burden on DL Ta'ita'i Uigalelei, CB Tacario Davis and transfer depth.
S Makell Esteen	No pro signing established	● ↓ A material 2025 starter is gone; no pro transaction or destination is established.

Defensive net: Likely modest downgrade from a very good 2025 defense; linebacker continuity and a returning interior anchor keep the floor respectable, but corner/edge turnover is substantial.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Jedd Fisch directly calls an offense that enters 2026 with a settled quarterback and a 2025 profile built on passing efficiency.	QB Demond Williams Jr., TE Decker DeGraaf and 69% offensive returning production give the unit a stable decision-making core.	The offense must replace RB Jonah Coleman and WR Denzel Boston while resolving RB1, a starting WR spot and parts of an injury-affected OL.
Defense	Ryan Walters uses a versatile four-/five-man-front structure with both man and zone answers.	The returning linebacker group, DL Ta'ita'i Uiagalelei, 2025 rush defense No. 11 and explosive-play prevention No.13 provide a strong base.	Two drafted corners and multiple front departures must be replaced, and a 2025 havoc-created rank of No.98 leaves pressure creation as the clearest statistical improvement area.
Special teams	Punter projects as a strength; placekicking is unsettled.	P Hunter Green carries Ray Guy recognition and a high-confidence projected punter role.	The kicker job remains open, while SP+ special teams ranks No. 96.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Demond Williams Jr. returns after 13 starts and is the offense's clearest stabilizer.
RB	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	RB Quaid Carr/RB Jayden Limar/RB Trey Cooley form an unresolved hierarchy after RB Jonah Coleman's departure.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium	WR Rashid Williams/WR Dezmen Roebuck lead a group replacing headline target WR Denzel Boston.
TE	● B+	● ↔	High	TE Decker DeGraaf returns after 11 starts, 32 catches and 360 yards with Mackey recognition.
OL	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	C Landen Hatchett and returning veterans provide experience, but injuries and multiple departures keep the best five unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium	DL Ta'ita'i Uiagalelei anchors a front replacing EDGE Zach Durfee, DT Anterio Thompson and other contributors.
LB	● B+	● ↔	High	LB Xe'ree Alexander/LB Jacob Manu/LB Zaydrius Rainey-Sale give Washington its strongest defensive continuity.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Returning DBs and transfer help must replace drafted CB Tacario Davis/CB Ephesians Prysock.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	P Hunter Green is Ray Guy-recognized, but placekicking remains unsettled.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Jedd Fisch and DC Ryan Walters return; Fisch remains the offensive play-caller.
Overall	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	Top-20 caliber with a settled quarterback and a strong two-way statistical base, but more personnel volatility than the ranking alone suggests.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Demond Williams Jr.	QB	● High-end conference starter / national breakout candidate	Maxwell Award	Established 13-game starter and the team's clearest stabilizer at the highest-leverage position.
Xe'ree Alexander	LB	● High-end conference starter	Butkus Award	Butkus recognition plus a high-confidence returning starting role makes him the best shorthand for defensive continuity.
Decker DeGraaf	TE	● High-end conference starter	John Mackey Award	Returns after 11 starts, 32 catches and 360 yards and gives the rebuilt skill group a proven middle-of-field piece.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Landen Hatchett	C	● High-end interior starter when healthy	Rimington Trophy	Rimington recognition and a projected center role matter, but his hand/wrist recovery is one of the offense's key availability monitors.
Ta'ita'i Uigalelei	DL	● Established Power 4 starter	-	Started all 13 games in 2025 and returned for a fifth season after an eligibility ruling, anchoring a front with major losses.
Rashid Williams	WR	● Projected major receiver	-	One of the principal returning receivers asked to absorb the target share vacated by Denzel Boston.
◆ Emmanuel Karnley (TR: Virginia)	CB	● Transfer starter/major-role candidate	-	Virginia transfer competing for first-unit corner work in the unit facing the largest defensive replacement burden.
◆ Hunter Green (TR: San Diego State)	P	● High-end specialist projection	Ray Guy Award	Ray Guy recognition and a high-confidence projected punter role make punting the more settled half of special teams.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Hard; the opening month gives Washington time to stabilize new skill/OL combinations, but the final four-game run sharply raises the cost of any early misses.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · SP+ SOS No. 23
Hardest stretch	Penn State → at Michigan State → Indiana → at Oregon
Swing games	at USC, Iowa, at Nebraska, Penn State
Advantage	Four straight home games open the season, and the lone bye comes before the road trip to Nebraska.
Expected	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A ranked AP/SP+ profile plus a settled quarterback should prevent Washington from being broadly overlooked, but the market can still overprice continuity if it treats the NFL losses at RB/WR/corner/edge as routine replacement.
Back them when	The price does not fully credit QB Demond Williams Jr.-led quarterback stability and the opponent is poorly equipped to exploit a reworked secondary or force obvious passing downs behind the unsettled OL.
Fade/pass when	Washington is laying a premium against a strong passing offense before corner/edge replacements are proven, or when OL health and the kicker competition remain unresolved.
Key monitor	OL health/best five, RB1 hierarchy, WR Christian Moss and the other starting-receiver role, corner rotation, defensive availability, kicker winner
Week 1 baseline	Washington -22.5 vs. Washington State · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Washington –22.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Washington’s top-20 case is built around QB Demond Williams Jr., a proven 2025 efficiency profile and meaningful continuity at linebacker/TE. Jedd Fisch still has a stable offensive decision-maker, while the defense retains enough spine to avoid treating the NFL losses as a total reset.

The volatility is concentrated at RB, WR, OL, corner and edge, where RB Jonah Coleman, WR Denzel Boston and multiple drafted defenders must be replaced. With **7.8 wins / 8-4** as the baseline and a brutal final four-game run, Washington’s ceiling depends on those new combinations stabilizing before November.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [OC update](#) · [QB watchlist](#) · [fall camp](#) · [WR update](#) · [defensive scheme](#) · [NFL departure](#)

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